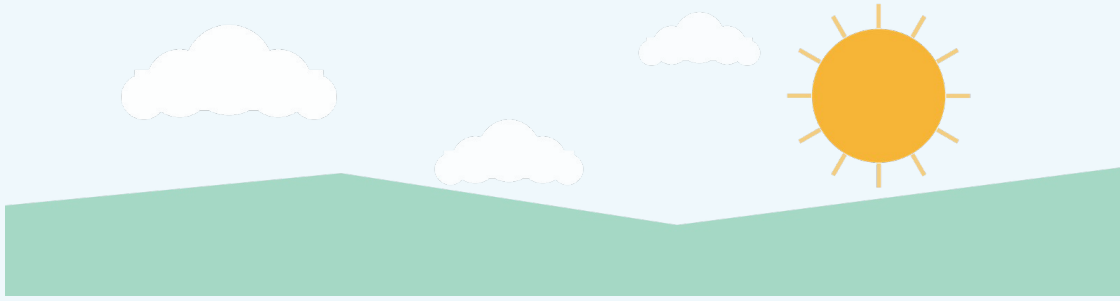


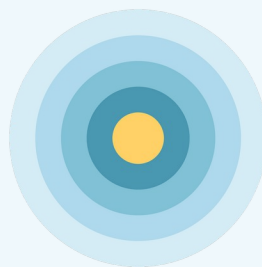


MINDSHIFT PSYCHOLOGICAL SERVICES

Calm Within

A Practical Guide to Managing Anxiety

Simple, evidence-informed tools — drawn from Dialectical Behavior Therapy (DBT), Emotional Freedom Techniques (EFT), and mindfulness-based practice — to help you understand your anxiety and build a calmer, steadier everyday life.



MindShift Psychological Services

(714) 584-9700

A Note Before You Begin

This ebook was created by MindShift Psychological Services as an educational resource for people who experience anxiety, stress, overthinking, and everyday emotional pressure. It is designed to help you understand anxiety more clearly and to offer practical, easy-to-use tools you can begin practicing right away.

This guide is intended for educational and self-help purposes only. It is not a substitute for individualized diagnosis, psychotherapy, medication management, or crisis care from a licensed mental health professional. Every person's experience with anxiety is different, and what helps one person may not fully address another person's needs.

If your anxiety feels severe, persistent, or is interfering significantly with your daily life, relationships, or work, please reach out to a licensed therapist or your medical provider. If you are in crisis or having thoughts of harming yourself, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline) in the United States, or go to your nearest emergency room.

You can reach us directly

If you'd like support applying anything in this guide, or would like to talk with a licensed clinician, MindShift Psychological Services can be reached at (714) 584-9700.

Take your time with this book. There is no need to complete it in one sitting, and there is no "right" pace. Read a section, try an exercise, and come back to it as often as you need.

What's Inside

1. Understanding Anxiety
2. Common Signs and Symptoms
3. Identifying Personal Triggers
4. Breathing and Grounding Exercises
5. Managing Overthinking and Negative Thoughts
6. ACT, CBT, and Exposure Therapy: More Tools for Your Toolbox
7. Building Healthy Daily Routines
8. Journaling and Mindfulness Techniques
9. Creating a Personal Anxiety Action Plan
10. Knowing When to Seek Professional Support

Throughout this guide you'll find:

- Clear, plain-language explanations
- Step-by-step exercises you can practice today
- Reflection questions and journaling prompts
- Self-assessment checklists
- A calm, encouraging, and supportive tone throughout

SECTION 1

Understanding Anxiety



Anxiety is one of the most common human experiences. At its core, anxiety is your body's built-in alarm system — a survival tool designed to keep you safe from danger. When your brain senses a threat, real or perceived, it activates the "fight, flight, or freeze" response: your heart beats faster, your muscles tense, your breathing quickens, and your attention narrows onto the perceived danger.

This response was essential for our ancestors facing physical threats. The challenge today is that this same alarm system can be triggered by things that aren't physically dangerous at all — a work deadline, a difficult conversation, a health worry, or even a string of anxious thoughts about the future. Your body reacts as though you're in danger, even when you're simply sitting at your desk or lying in bed.

It's important to understand that anxiety itself is not a flaw or a weakness. It is a normal, protective response. Occasional anxiety before a big event, an important decision, or an unfamiliar situation is a healthy part of being human. Anxiety becomes a problem when it shows up too often, too intensely, or in situations that don't call for it — when the alarm system starts going off even when there's no real fire.

A Spectrum, Not a Switch

Anxiety exists on a spectrum. On one end is everyday nervousness — the flutter before a presentation, the tension before a first date. On the other end is more persistent anxiety that can affect sleep, concentration, relationships, and physical health. Most people move along this spectrum throughout their lives depending on what's happening around them.

Wherever you currently sit on that spectrum, this guide is designed to meet you there. The goal isn't to eliminate anxiety completely — some anxiety is useful and even protective. The goal is to help you recognize when anxiety is running the show, understand what's fueling it, and build a toolbox of strategies so you can respond with more calm and clarity.

Why DBT and EFT?

This guide draws on two complementary approaches:

- Dialectical Behavior Therapy (DBT) — originally developed to help people manage intense emotion, DBT offers concrete skills in four areas: mindfulness, distress tolerance, emotion regulation, and interpersonal effectiveness. Its core idea is powerful: you can accept where you are right now while also working to make things better. You don't have to fight your anxiety to change your relationship with it.
- Emotional Freedom Techniques (EFT), often called "tapping" — a mind-body approach that combines gently tapping on specific points of the body with focused attention on a feeling or thought. Many people find it helps take the edge off acute anxiety and stress fairly quickly, and it pairs naturally with the mindfulness and self-soothing skills found in DBT.

Alongside these two frameworks, you'll also find grounding exercises, cognitive strategies for managing overthinking, and simple daily habits that support a calmer nervous system overall. None of these tools require special training or equipment — just a willingness to practice.

Reflect

Think of a recent moment when you felt anxious. What was happening around you? What did you notice in your body first?

Common Myths About Anxiety

Myth: "I should just be able to think my way out of it." Anxiety is a whole-body response, not purely a thinking problem. That's why physical tools like breathing and tapping matter just as much as changing your thoughts.

Myth: "Avoiding what makes me anxious is the safest choice." In the short term, avoidance brings relief. Over time, though, it usually reinforces anxiety by confirming to your brain that the situation was truly dangerous.

Myth: "Other people don't struggle with this." Anxiety is extremely common — many people you interact with daily are managing their own version of it, even if it isn't visible.

Myth: "If I have anxiety, something is wrong with me." Anxiety is a normal human response, and even frequent or intense anxiety is highly treatable. It reflects a nervous system working overtime, not a personal failing.

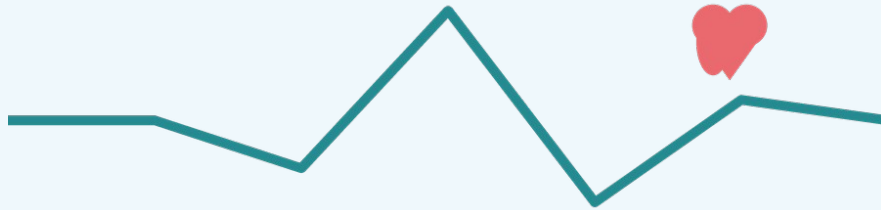
How This Guide Is Organized

Each section builds on the one before it. Sections 2 and 3 help you understand your personal pattern of anxiety and what tends to trigger it. Sections 4, 5, and 6 offer concrete tools for the moment anxiety shows up. Sections 7 and 8 focus on the daily habits and practices that lower your overall baseline of stress. Section

9 helps you bring everything together into a personalized plan, and Section 10 covers when and how to seek additional support.

SECTION 2

Common Signs and Symptoms



Anxiety doesn't only show up as "worry." It can appear in your body, your thoughts, your emotions, and your behavior — often all at once. Recognizing your own personal pattern of symptoms is one of the most useful first steps in managing anxiety, because it helps you notice anxiety earlier, before it builds into overwhelm.

Physical Signs

- Racing or pounding heart
- Shortness of breath or a tight chest
- Muscle tension, especially in the shoulders, jaw, or stomach
- Restlessness or feeling "on edge"
- Fatigue, despite feeling wired
- Trouble falling or staying asleep
- Stomach discomfort, nausea, or appetite changes
- Sweating, trembling, or dizziness

Mental and Emotional Signs

- Racing thoughts or a mind that won't slow down
- Difficulty concentrating or a feeling of "blacking out"
- Persistent worry about things that might go wrong
- A sense of dread or impending danger without a clear cause
- Irritability or feeling short-tempered
- Feeling overwhelmed by decisions, large or small

Behavioral Signs

- Avoiding certain places, people, or situations

- Procrastinating on tasks that feel overwhelming
- Seeking frequent reassurance from others
- Checking behaviors (re-reading messages, re-checking locks, etc.)
- Withdrawing from social activities

You may notice a few of these signs, many of them, or a pattern that shifts depending on the day. That's completely normal — anxiety looks different from person to person, and it can even look different for the same person from one season of life to the next.

Self-Assessment: Notice Your Pattern

Check any symptoms you've experienced regularly over the past two weeks. There's no scoring here — this is simply a way to build awareness.

- ☐ Racing or pounding heart
- ☐ Tight chest or shortness of breath
- ☐ Muscle tension or a clenched jaw
- ☐ Trouble sleeping
- ☐ Racing or repetitive thoughts
- ☐ Difficulty concentrating
- ☐ Irritability
- ☐ Avoiding certain situations
- ☐ Seeking frequent reassurance
- ☐ A general sense of unease or dread

Reflect

Which two or three symptoms show up most often for you? Where in your body do you first notice anxiety building?

Anxiety vs. an Anxiety Disorder

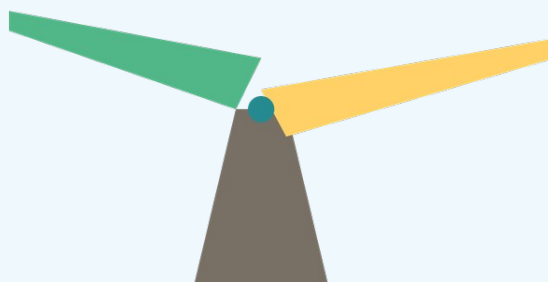
Occasional anxiety is a normal part of life. Anxiety may rise to the level of a diagnosable disorder — such as Generalized Anxiety Disorder, Panic Disorder, or Social Anxiety Disorder — when it becomes excessive, persistent (often lasting six months or more), and begins to significantly interfere with daily functioning. Only a licensed clinician can make a formal diagnosis, but noticing the frequency, intensity, and impact of your symptoms can help you decide whether it's time to seek additional support (see Section 10).

Tracking Symptoms Over Time

Because anxiety can fluctuate, it's often more useful to track your symptoms over a week or two rather than judging a single day. Consider using the Practice Tracker near the end of this guide, or simply jotting a quick note each evening about your anxiety level from 0 (calm) to 10 (extremely anxious). Patterns often emerge — certain days of the week, times of day, or situations that consistently correlate with higher anxiety.

SECTION 3

Identifying Personal Triggers



A trigger is anything — a situation, thought, person, place, or even a physical sensation — that sets off your anxiety response. Some triggers are obvious, like public speaking or a stressful deadline. Others are quieter and easier to miss, like a certain tone of voice, a cluttered room, or scrolling social media late at night.

Learning your personal triggers doesn't mean you need to avoid them forever. In fact, avoidance often makes anxiety stronger over time, because it teaches your brain that the situation truly is dangerous. Instead, the goal is awareness: when you can name a trigger, you can prepare for it, respond to it skillfully, and take away some of its power.

Common Categories of Triggers

- Situational — deadlines, public speaking, crowded spaces, driving, medical appointments
- Relational — conflict, criticism, feeling rejected or misunderstood, social gatherings
- Cognitive — perfectionism, "what if" thinking, comparing yourself to others
- Physical — poor sleep, caffeine, low blood sugar, illness, hormonal changes
- Environmental — noise, clutter, financial stress, news and social media
- Anniversary or memory-based — dates, smells, or situations linked to a past difficult experience

The Trigger-Thought-Feeling-Behavior Chain

Anxiety often follows a chain reaction: a trigger occurs, it activates a thought (often automatic and not fully conscious), that thought produces a feeling, and the feeling drives a behavior. Slowing down and mapping this chain can reveal exactly where you have the most room to intervene.

Example: Trigger — an unanswered text message. Thought — "They're upset with me." Feeling — anxious, uneasy. Behavior — sending several follow-up messages or replaying the conversation repeatedly.

Try This

The next time you notice anxiety rising, pause and ask: What just happened right before this feeling started? That moment is very often your trigger.

Trigger Mapping Worksheet

Use the space below to identify three situations that reliably trigger anxiety for you, along with the thought, feeling, and behavior that tend to follow.

Trigger 1:

Situation

Automatic thought

Feeling / body sensation

What I typically do in response

Trigger 2:

Situation

Automatic thought

Feeling / body sensation

What I typically do in response

Trigger 3:

Situation

Automatic thought

Feeling / body sensation

What I typically do in response

From Awareness to Response

Once you can see your trigger–thought–feeling–behavior chain clearly, you have several points where you can intervene. You might not be able to prevent the trigger itself (an unanswered text will happen sometimes), but you have real influence over the thought you attach to it, the way you ride out the feeling, and the behavior you choose next. Sections 4 and 5 of this guide give you specific tools for exactly these moments.

A Worked Example

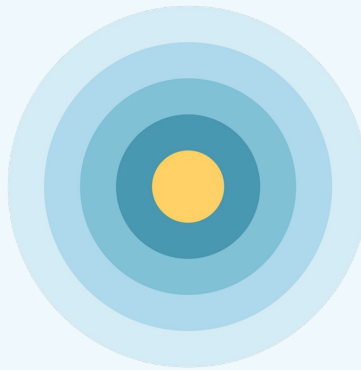
Trigger: A coworker doesn't respond to an email for several hours.

Old pattern: Thought — "I must have done something wrong." Feeling — anxious, embarrassed. Behavior — sending a follow-up apology email and mentally replaying the situation for the rest of the day.

New pattern: Notice the thought as just a thought ("I'm having the thought that I did something wrong"). Use a grounding or breathing exercise from Section 4 to settle the physical anxiety. Gently question the thought using the five questions from Section 5 — is there real evidence, or is this catastrophizing? Choose a response that fits the facts, such as simply waiting for a reply.

SECTION 4

Breathing and Grounding Exercises



When anxiety activates your body's alarm system, your breathing tends to become shallow and fast, which in turn signals to your brain that danger is present — even if it isn't. The good news is that this works in reverse too: intentionally slowing your breath sends a message of safety back to your nervous system. The exercises below are simple, portable, and can be used anywhere, anytime you feel anxiety building.

Box Breathing

Box breathing is used by everyone from therapists to first responders because it's simple and effective.

1. Breathe in slowly through your nose for a count of 4.
2. Hold your breath gently for a count of 4.
3. Breathe out slowly through your mouth for a count of 4.
4. Hold at the bottom for a count of 4.
5. Repeat for 4 to 8 rounds, or until you feel your body settle.

4-7-8 Breathing

This pattern is especially helpful before bed or during a moment of acute stress.

1. Inhale quietly through your nose for a count of 4.
2. Hold your breath for a count of 7.
3. Exhale completely through your mouth for a count of 8, making a soft whoosh sound.
4. Repeat for 3 to 4 cycles.

The 5-4-3-2-1 Grounding Technique

Grounding uses your five senses to pull your attention out of anxious thoughts and back into the present moment, where you are actually safe.

1. Name 5 things you can see around you.
2. Name 4 things you can physically touch or feel (the chair beneath you, your clothing, the ground).
3. Name 3 things you can hear.
4. Name 2 things you can smell (or two of your favorite smells, if none are present).
5. Name 1 thing you can taste.

EFT Tapping (Emotional Freedom Techniques)

EFT tapping combines gentle tapping on specific points of the body with a spoken statement that names the feeling and offers self-acceptance. Many people find it brings noticeable relief within a few minutes, and it can be a useful companion to the breathing exercises above.

1. Identify the feeling. Name what you're experiencing right now (for example, "anxious about my presentation") and rate its intensity from 0 (none) to 10 (extreme).
2. Create a setup statement that names the feeling and pairs it with self-acceptance, such as: "Even though I feel anxious about this presentation, I fully accept myself."
3. Tap the karate chop point (the outer edge of either hand) about 5–7 times while repeating your setup statement 3 times.
4. Move through the tapping points in order, tapping each about 5–7 times while saying a short reminder phrase (for example, "this anxious feeling"): eyebrow, side of the eye, under the eye, under the nose, chin, collarbone, under the arm, and top of the head.
5. Take a slow breath, and re-rate the intensity of the feeling from 0 to 10.
6. Repeat the sequence as needed until the intensity comes down.

A Note on EFT

EFT is a gentle, low-risk self-soothing tool that many people find calming, though the scientific evidence is still developing. Think of it as one option among several rather than a stand-alone treatment for clinical anxiety.

Progressive Muscle Relaxation

This technique works by intentionally tensing and then releasing different muscle groups, which helps your body recognize the difference between tension and relaxation — a contrast that's often hard to notice when you're anxious most of the day.

1. Starting with your feet, tense the muscles as tightly as you comfortably can for 5 seconds.

2. Release the tension all at once and notice the feeling of relaxation for 10-15 seconds.
3. Move upward through each muscle group — calves, thighs, stomach, hands, arms, shoulders, face — repeating the tense-and-release pattern.
4. Finish by taking a few slow, deep breaths and noticing how your whole body feels.

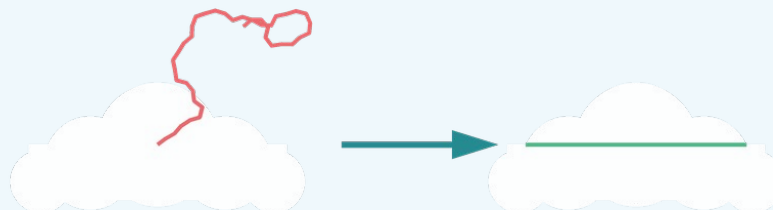
Which Technique Should You Use?

- Feeling physically wound up (racing heart, tight chest)? Start with box breathing or 4-7-8 breathing.
- Feeling disconnected, spiraling, or "stuck in your head"? Try 5-4-3-2-1 grounding.
- Feeling a specific, nameable worry or emotional charge? Try EFT tapping.
- Feeling generally tense throughout your body? Try progressive muscle relaxation.

There's no wrong choice — the best technique is the one you'll actually use. Consider practicing each one when you're calm, so it feels familiar and accessible when anxiety shows up.

SECTION 5

Managing Overthinking and Negative Thoughts



Overthinking is one of the most exhausting parts of anxiety. Your mind loops the same worry again and again, searches for certainty it can't find, and often lands on the worst-case scenario. This pattern is sometimes called rumination (dwelling on the past) or catastrophizing (jumping to the worst possible future outcome).

It helps to remember that overthinking is not a character flaw — it's often your brain's attempt to solve a problem or prevent something bad from happening. The trouble is that this strategy rarely works. Thinking about a worry over and over doesn't usually produce a solution; it mostly produces more anxiety.

DBT's Wise Mind

DBT describes two states of mind that often pull us in different directions: emotion mind, where feelings drive our thoughts and actions, and reasonable mind, where logic and facts take over. Wise mind is the balance point between the two — a place where you can honor your emotions while still thinking clearly. When you notice yourself overthinking, pausing to ask, "What would my wise mind say here?" can create just enough space to respond thoughtfully instead of spiraling.

Observe and Describe, Without Judgment

A core DBT mindfulness skill is to simply observe a thought — noticing it the way you'd notice a cloud passing overhead — rather than treating every thought as a fact that demands immediate action. You might silently say to yourself, "I'm having the thought that..." This small shift creates distance between you and the thought, which is often enough to loosen its grip.

Five Questions to Challenge Anxious Thoughts

When you notice a spiral of worry, try gently questioning the thought with these five questions:

1. What is the evidence for and against this thought?
2. Is there another way to look at this situation?
3. What would I say to a friend having this exact thought?
4. What is the most likely outcome, not just the worst-case one?
5. If the worst did happen, how would I realistically cope?

Scheduled Worry Time

If worries tend to intrude throughout the day, try setting aside one 15-minute "worry window" — the same time each day. When an anxious thought shows up outside that window, jot it down and remind yourself you'll address it during your scheduled time. This trains your brain to trust that worries will be heard, without letting them take over your entire day.

Using EFT for Persistent Negative Thoughts

The tapping sequence from the previous section can also be applied directly to a specific negative thought. Try a setup statement such as: "Even though I keep having this thought that ____, I choose to accept myself and find some calm." Tap through the points while repeating a short version of the thought, then notice whether its intensity has softened.

Reflect

What is a thought that has been looping for you lately? Try running it through the five questions above.

SECTION 6

ACT, CBT, and Exposure Therapy: More Tools for Your Toolbox

DBT, EFT, and the grounding tools you've already learned are a strong foundation. This section adds three more well-established approaches — Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT), Acceptance and Commitment Therapy (ACT), and exposure therapy — each offering a slightly different angle on managing anxiety. You don't need to use all of them at once; simply notice which ideas resonate most with how your mind works.

Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT)

CBT is one of the most researched and widely used approaches for anxiety. Its central idea is straightforward: our thoughts, feelings, and behaviors are all connected, and changing one can shift the other two. Anxious thinking patterns — like catastrophizing, mind-reading, or all-or-nothing thinking — tend to fuel anxious feelings, which then drive avoidance or other unhelpful behaviors. CBT works by identifying these thinking patterns and testing them against real evidence, much like the five-question exercise you practiced in Section 5.

Common Thinking Traps

- All-or-nothing thinking — seeing situations in extremes, with no middle ground ("If it's not perfect, I've failed.")
- Catastrophizing — assuming the worst-case outcome is the most likely one
- Mind-reading — assuming you know what others are thinking, usually something negative about you
- Fortune-telling — predicting a negative outcome as though it's already certain
- Should statements — holding yourself to rigid, often unrealistic standards ("I should always be calm.")
- Emotional reasoning — treating a feeling as proof of fact ("I feel anxious, so something must be wrong.")

Thought Record Worksheet

A thought record is a core CBT tool for slowing down and examining an anxious thought. Try it with a recent situation.

Situation:

Automatic thought:

Thinking trap, if any (see list above):

Evidence that supports the thought:

Evidence against the thought:

A more balanced thought:

Acceptance and Commitment Therapy (ACT)

Where CBT often focuses on changing the content of a thought, ACT takes a different approach: rather than fighting anxious thoughts and feelings, ACT helps you change your relationship to them, so they have less power over your choices. The goal isn't to eliminate anxiety — it's to keep moving toward a meaningful life even when anxiety is present.

ACT is built around six core skills that work together to build what's often called psychological flexibility — the ability to stay present, hold space for difficult feelings, and still act in line with what matters to you.

- Acceptance — allowing uncomfortable thoughts and feelings to be present, instead of struggling against them
- Cognitive defusion — seeing a thought as just a thought, not a command or a fact
- Being present — anchoring your attention in the here and now, rather than the past or future
- Self-as-context — recognizing yourself as more than any single thought or feeling you're having
- Values — identifying what genuinely matters to you, as a compass for your choices

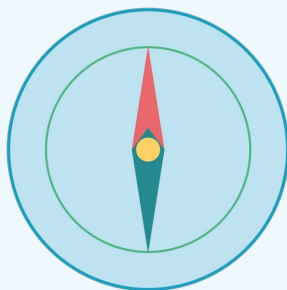
- Committed action — taking real steps toward your values, even while anxiety is present

Cognitive Defusion in Practice

Cognitive defusion is one of the most practical ACT skills to try right away. The idea is to create a little distance between you and a thought, so it feels less like an urgent fact and more like a passing mental event.

- Add the phrase "I'm having the thought that..." before a worry ("I'm having the thought that I'll embarrass myself") rather than stating it as fact.
- Silently thank your mind: "Thanks, mind, for trying to protect me," then continue with what you were doing.
- Say the thought slowly in a silly voice, or picture it written on a leaf floating down a stream and drifting out of view.

Values Clarification



Values are different from goals — a goal is something you complete, while a value is a direction you continue moving toward (for example, "being a supportive friend" rather than "attend one gathering this month"). Anxiety often narrows our world by encouraging avoidance; reconnecting with your values can help you choose actions that matter to you, even when anxiety is in the room.

What matters most to me in my relationships:

What matters most to me in my work or daily activities:

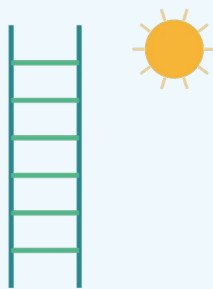
One small action, aligned with a value above, that I could take this week — even if anxiety comes along for the ride:

Exposure Therapy

Exposure therapy is grounded in a simple but powerful principle: avoidance keeps anxiety alive, while gradually and safely facing feared situations teaches your brain that they're more manageable than it assumed. Each time you avoid something anxiety-provoking, you get short-term relief, but you also reinforce the belief that the situation was dangerous. Exposure interrupts that cycle.

This doesn't mean throwing yourself into your biggest fear all at once. Exposure works best when it's gradual, structured, and paced in a way that feels challenging but manageable — often with the guidance of a therapist, especially for more intense fears, panic, or trauma-related anxiety.

Building an Exposure Hierarchy



An exposure hierarchy is a ranked list of anxiety-provoking situations related to one specific fear, ordered from least to most distressing. Many people use a 0–100 distress scale (sometimes called SUDS, or Subjective Units of Distress) to rank each step.

1. Choose one specific fear or avoided situation to work on.
2. Brainstorm several related situations, big and small, that connect to that fear.
3. Rate each one from 0 (no distress) to 100 (extreme distress).
4. Arrange them from lowest to highest distress rating.
5. Starting with the lowest step, practice staying in that situation (using a breathing or grounding tool if needed) until your distress noticeably drops.
6. Once a step feels manageable, move to the next one — repeating steps as needed rather than rushing.

Example: Social Anxiety Hierarchy

- 20 — Making eye contact with a cashier
- 35 — Saying hello to a neighbor
- 50 — Asking a question in a small group
- 65 — Making a phone call to schedule an appointment
- 80 — Speaking up in a meeting
- 95 — Giving a presentation to a large group

My Exposure Hierarchy Worksheet

Fear or avoided situation I want to work on:

Step 1 (lowest distress):

Step 2:

Step 3:

Step 4:

Step 5 (highest distress):

A Note on Exposure

Some anxiety-related fears — including panic disorder, OCD, phobias, and trauma-related anxiety — respond especially well to exposure therapy done with a trained therapist, who can help pace it safely and support you through the process. If a fear feels too large to approach alone, that's a good reason to reach out for professional support (see Section 10).

Choosing an Approach

- Want to examine and reshape an anxious thought? Try a CBT thought record.
- Want to loosen a thought's grip without necessarily changing it? Try ACT defusion.
- Want to reconnect with what matters and take a values-aligned step? Try ACT values work.
- Ready to gradually face an avoided situation? Try building an exposure hierarchy.

These approaches overlap and complement each other — many therapists blend elements of CBT, ACT, DBT, and exposure work together, tailored to what a person needs most.

SECTION 7

Building Healthy Daily Routines



Anxiety isn't only managed in the moment it appears — it's also shaped by the daily habits that support (or undermine) your nervous system over time. Small, consistent routines create a foundation of stability that makes it easier to handle stress when it arises.

Sleep

Sleep and anxiety influence each other in both directions: poor sleep increases anxiety, and anxiety makes it harder to sleep. Aim for a consistent sleep and wake time, even on weekends. Wind down for 20–30 minutes before bed without screens, and consider pairing this time with one of the breathing exercises from Section 4.

Movement

You don't need an intense workout to benefit — even a 10 to 15 minute walk can lower stress hormones and clear a foggy, anxious mind. Movement gives excess nervous energy somewhere to go and is one of the most reliable natural mood regulators available.

Nourishment

Skipping meals or relying heavily on caffeine and sugar can mimic or worsen anxiety symptoms (racing heart, jitteriness, irritability). Try to eat regular, balanced meals, and notice how your body responds to caffeine — for some people, especially those prone to anxiety, cutting back can make a noticeable difference.

Connection

Isolation tends to feed anxiety, while supportive connection tends to soften it. Even brief, regular contact with people who feel safe to you — a short call, a coffee, a text check-in — can meaningfully lower your baseline stress.

Boundaries with Technology and News

Constant exposure to news and social media can keep your nervous system in a low-grade state of alert. Consider setting specific times to check the news or social media, rather than leaving it open throughout the day, and notice how your anxiety responds.

A Simple Daily Anchor Routine

Consider building a short routine — even five to ten minutes — around these four anchors each day:

- Morning: a few minutes of quiet breathing or intention-setting before checking your phone
- Midday: a short walk or stretch break, ideally outside
- Evening: a screen-free wind-down period before bed
- Ongoing: one small moment of connection with another person

Daily Routine Checklist

Use this checklist to notice which anchors are already part of your day, and which you'd like to build in.

- ☐ Consistent sleep and wake time
- ☐ Regular, balanced meals
- ☐ At least one short period of movement
- ☐ A moment of connection with another person
- ☐ A screen-free wind-down before bed
- ☐ Boundaries around news or social media checking
- ☐ One breathing or grounding exercise practiced today

Weekly Routine Planner

Use the lines below to sketch out your anchors for the week ahead. You don't need to fill in every line — start with whatever feels realistic.

Monday — Morning anchor / Midday anchor / Evening anchor:

Tuesday — Morning anchor / Midday anchor / Evening anchor:

Wednesday — Morning anchor / Midday anchor / Evening anchor:

Thursday — Morning anchor / Midday anchor / Evening anchor:

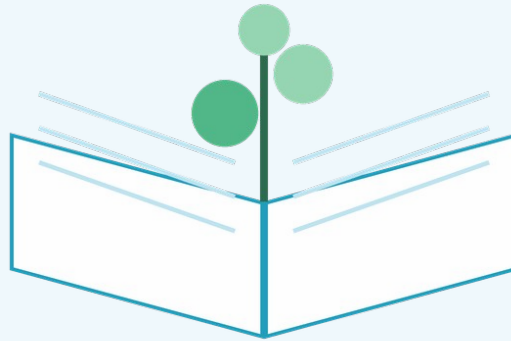
Friday — Morning anchor / Midday anchor / Evening anchor:

Saturday — Morning anchor / Midday anchor / Evening anchor:

Sunday — Morning anchor / Midday anchor / Evening anchor:

SECTION 8

Journaling and Mindfulness Techniques



Journaling and mindfulness both help create space between you and your anxious thoughts. Rather than getting swept up in a feeling, these practices let you step back, observe, and respond with more intention.

DBT's Mindfulness "What" Skills

DBT describes three things you do when practicing mindfulness:

- Observe — simply notice what's happening, in your body, mind, and surroundings, without trying to change it yet.
- Describe — put words to what you noticed ("my chest feels tight," "I'm having the thought that...")
- Participate — fully engage in the present activity, whatever it is, rather than being pulled between the past and future.

DBT's Mindfulness "How" Skills

These describe the quality you bring to the practice:

- Non-judgmentally — noticing without labeling things as "good" or "bad"
- One-mindfully — doing one thing at a time, with full attention
- Effectively — focusing on what works, rather than what feels "right" in the moment

A Simple Daily Mindfulness Practice

Set aside 5 minutes. Sit comfortably and bring your attention to your breath. When your mind wanders (which it will — that's completely normal), gently notice where it went and guide your attention back to your breath, without criticizing yourself for wandering. Over time, this simple practice strengthens your ability to notice anxious thoughts earlier and respond to them more skillfully.

Journaling Prompts

Journaling gives anxious thoughts somewhere to go besides looping in your head. You don't need to write for long — even five minutes can help. Try one of the following prompts whenever you sit down to write:

- What am I feeling right now, and where do I notice it in my body?
- What thought keeps showing up for me today?
- What is one thing within my control right now, and one thing that isn't?
- What would I tell a friend who was feeling exactly what I'm feeling?
- What is one small thing that went well today?
- What do I need right now — rest, connection, movement, or something else?

Daily Reflection Page

Use the space below for today's check-in.

Date:

How I'm feeling right now:

What's on my mind:

One thing I can do for myself today:

Additional Reflection Page

Date:

How I'm feeling right now:

What's on my mind:

One thing I can do for myself today:

Additional Reflection Page

Date:

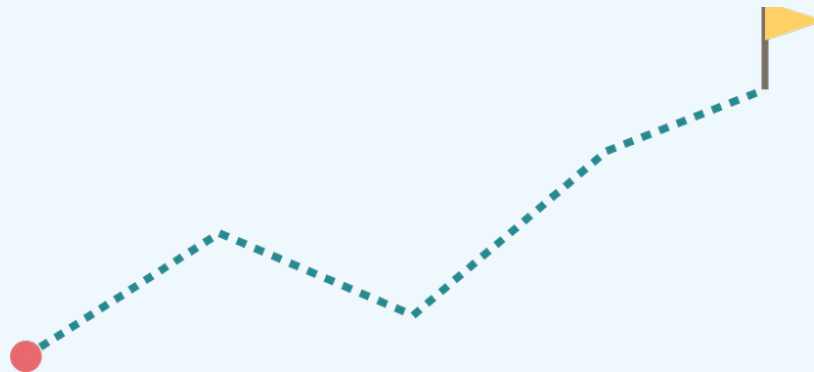
How I'm feeling right now:

What's on my mind:

One thing I can do for myself today:

SECTION 9

Creating a Personal Anxiety Action Plan



You've now been introduced to a range of tools — breathing exercises, grounding techniques, EFT tapping, cognitive strategies, daily routines, and mindfulness practices. An action plan brings these together into a personalized, easy-to-follow reference you can turn to whenever anxiety shows up.

Step 1: My Early Warning Signs

List two or three signs that tell you anxiety is starting to build (refer back to Section 2 if helpful).

Step 2: My Most Common Triggers

List your top two or three triggers (refer back to Section 3).

Step 3: My Go-To In-the-Moment Tools

Choose two or three techniques from Section 4 that felt most accessible to you.

- ☐ Box breathing
- ☐ 4-7-8 breathing
- ☐ 5-4-3-2-1 grounding
- ☐ EFT tapping
- ☐ Other: _____

Step 4: My Daily Foundation Habits

List one or two daily habits from Section 7 you want to build or protect.

Step 5: My Support System

List the people, resources, or professionals you can reach out to when anxiety feels like more than you can manage alone.

Keep It Visible

Consider writing a short version of this plan on a card you keep in your wallet or phone, so it's available exactly when you need it most.

My One-Page Anxiety Plan

When I notice: _____

My first step will be: _____

If that doesn't help, I will: _____

If I still feel overwhelmed, I will reach out to: _____

SECTION 10

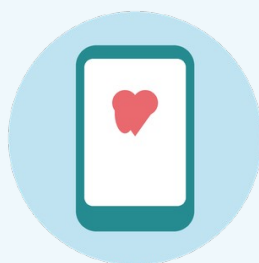
Knowing When to Seek Professional Support

Self-help tools like the ones in this guide can meaningfully reduce everyday anxiety, but they aren't meant to replace professional care when it's needed. Reaching out for support is not a sign of failure — it's an act of self-respect and often the fastest path toward real relief.

Signs It May Be Time to Reach Out

- Anxiety is interfering with work, school, sleep, or relationships
- You're avoiding more and more places, people, or activities
- Physical symptoms (chest tightness, panic attacks, GI issues) are frequent or intense
- You're relying on alcohol, substances, or other unhealthy coping methods to get through the day
- Self-help strategies aren't providing enough relief, even with consistent practice
- You're experiencing persistent sadness, hopelessness, or thoughts of self-harm

What Professional Support Can Look Like



Therapy for anxiety often includes approaches like Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT), Dialectical Behavior Therapy (DBT), Acceptance and Commitment Therapy (ACT), or EMDR, depending on your specific needs and history. A licensed clinician can also help determine whether medication, in coordination with a prescribing provider, may be a helpful part of your care.

Therapy isn't only for crisis moments. Many people find real value in working with a therapist simply to build stronger coping skills, better understand their patterns, and have consistent support as they navigate life's stressors.

Reach Out Anytime

MindShift Psychological Services is here to help. Call us at (714) 584-9700 to learn more about our services or to schedule an appointment with a licensed clinician.

Frequently Asked Questions

"Will I need to be in therapy forever?" Not necessarily. Many people attend therapy for a defined period to build skills and work through a specific challenge, then step back once they feel equipped. Others prefer ongoing support. There's no single right answer — it depends on your goals.

"What if I've never been to therapy before?" That's completely normal, and most therapists are experienced in helping first-time clients feel comfortable. The first session is typically focused on understanding your history and what brought you in, not diving into anything you're not ready for.

"Is medication necessary?" Not always. Many people manage anxiety successfully with therapy and lifestyle strategies alone. For others, medication can be a helpful part of a broader treatment plan. This is a decision best made together with a licensed provider based on your specific situation.

If You're in Crisis

If you are having thoughts of harming yourself or are in crisis, please seek immediate help:

- Call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, available 24/7 in the United States)
- Call 911 or go to your nearest emergency room
- Reach out to a trusted person and let them know you need support right now

SECTION BONUS

Your 7-Day Practice Tracker

Skills work best with repetition. Research on habit-building consistently shows that short, daily practice — even just a few minutes — builds new patterns more reliably than occasional, longer sessions. Use the tracker below to practice one tool each day for the next week. Mix and match from breathing, grounding, EFT tapping, journaling, or a daily routine anchor.

How to Use This Tracker

Pick one technique each day, even on days that feel calm. Practicing when you're not anxious builds the skill so it's ready and familiar when you need it most.

Day 1

Technique I practiced:

How I felt before (0-10) and after (0-10):

One thing I noticed:

Day 2

Technique I practiced:

How I felt before (0-10) and after (0-10):

One thing I noticed:

Day 3

Technique I practiced:

How I felt before (0-10) and after (0-10):

One thing I noticed:

Day 4

Technique I practiced:

How I felt before (0-10) and after (0-10):

One thing I noticed:

Day 5

Technique I practiced:

How I felt before (0-10) and after (0-10):

One thing I noticed:

Day 6

Technique I practiced:

How I felt before (0-10) and after (0-10):

One thing I noticed:

Day 7

Technique I practiced:

How I felt before (0-10) and after (0-10):

One thing I noticed:

End-of-Week Reflection

What technique felt most helpful this week?

What made it easier or harder to practice on certain days?

What do I want to keep doing next week?

Quick-Reference Glossary

A short glossary of terms used throughout this guide, so you can quickly look up a concept whenever you need a refresher.

Anxiety

The body's natural alarm response to a perceived threat, involving physical, mental, and behavioral reactions designed to keep you safe.

Trigger

Any situation, thought, person, place, or sensation that activates an anxiety response.

Grounding

A category of techniques that use your senses or body awareness to bring your attention back to the present moment.

Dialectical Behavior Therapy (DBT)

A therapy approach built around four skill areas — mindfulness, distress tolerance, emotion regulation, and interpersonal effectiveness — that emphasizes balancing acceptance with change.

Wise Mind

A DBT concept describing the balance point between emotion-driven thinking and purely logical thinking, where clear, values-aligned decisions are easier to make.

Emotional Freedom Techniques (EFT / Tapping)

A self-soothing technique that pairs gentle tapping on specific points of the body with a spoken statement naming a feeling and offering self-acceptance.

Rumination

Repeatedly dwelling on past events, mistakes, or worries without reaching resolution.

Catastrophizing

A thinking pattern where the mind jumps to the worst possible outcome in a given situation.

Cognitive Reframing

The practice of examining and adjusting an unhelpful thought pattern by considering evidence and alternative perspectives.

Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT)

A therapy approach based on the connection between thoughts, feelings, and behaviors, which works by identifying and testing unhelpful thinking patterns.

Acceptance and Commitment Therapy (ACT)

A therapy approach that emphasizes accepting difficult thoughts and feelings, creating distance from unhelpful thoughts (defusion), and taking action aligned with personal values.

Cognitive Defusion

An ACT technique for creating distance from a thought so it feels less like a command or fact and more like a passing mental event.

Exposure Therapy

A gradual, structured approach to facing avoided or feared situations, based on the principle that avoidance maintains anxiety while safe repeated exposure reduces it.

Exposure Hierarchy

A ranked list of situations related to a specific fear, ordered from least to most distressing, used to guide gradual exposure.

About MindShift Psychological Services

MindShift Psychological Services is dedicated to helping individuals build healthier, calmer, and more balanced lives. Our clinicians work with clients experiencing anxiety, stress, relationship challenges, and a wide range of other concerns, using evidence-informed approaches tailored to each person's needs.

This ebook reflects our belief that everyone deserves accessible, practical tools for managing everyday mental and emotional challenges — whether or not they're currently working with a therapist. We hope you've found it useful, and we're always here if you'd like additional support.

Get in Touch

Call MindShift Psychological Services at (714) 584-9700 to ask questions, request more resources, or schedule an appointment (Feel free to call or text anytime of the day!)

If you would like to meditate with us, please visit <https://mindshiftwellnesscenter.com/meditation-videos/>

Ways to Keep Building on What You've Learned

- Revisit the exercises in this guide regularly, not just when anxiety feels intense
- Share the daily anchor routine or journaling prompts with someone you trust
- Consider individual therapy if you'd like more personalized, ongoing support
- Be patient with yourself — building new patterns takes practice and repetition

Notes

Use this space for anything that comes up as you work through this guide — thoughts, reminders, or ideas you want to return to.

Notes

A Final Word



Managing anxiety is not about becoming someone who never feels anxious again. It's about building a steadier relationship with your mind and body — learning to recognize what's happening, responding with tools that work for you, and treating yourself with the same compassion you'd offer someone you care about.

You won't get it perfect every time, and that's completely okay. Every time you practice one of these skills — even imperfectly — you're building a little more resilience for the next time anxiety shows up.

We hope this guide has given you a starting place. Revisit it as often as you need, and remember that support is always available.

MindShift Psychological Services

(714) 584-9700

You don't have to navigate this alone.